

SHOGI · VARIANT 17 OF 24

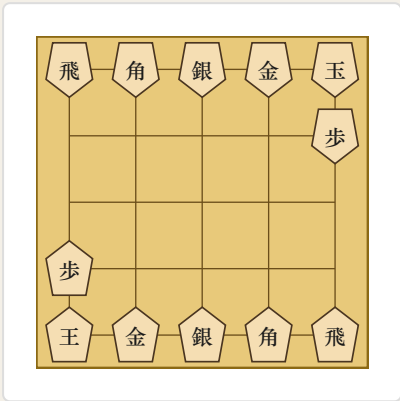
# Minishogi

**5×5**  
BOARD

**2**  
PLAYERS

# MINISHOGI

Minishogi was invented (or rediscovered) around 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka, Japan. It applies Standard Shogi rules to a 5×5 board, reducing each player’s force to five pieces and the promotion zone to the single back rank. Game mechanics are not copyrightable; the rules have been freely published for over 50 years.



Minishogi — starting position

## SETUP

**Board:** 5×5 grid, 25 squares.

**Pieces per player:** 6 (King, Rook, Bishop, Gold General, Silver General, one Pawn). No Knights or Lances: the board is too small for their jump.

**Starting position:**

| PLAYER         | RANK   | PIECES (FILES 5–1, LEFT TO RIGHT)    |
|----------------|--------|--------------------------------------|
| White (top)    | Rank 5 | Rook · Bishop · Silver · Gold · King |
| White          | Rank 4 | Pawn at file 1 only                  |
| Black (bottom) | Rank 1 | King · Gold · Silver · Bishop · Rook |
| Black          | Rank 2 | Pawn at file 5 only                  |

## PIECES

| PIECE          | MOVEMENT                                                     |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| King           | One square in any direction. Cannot move into check.         |
| Rook           | Any number of squares orthogonally.                          |
| Bishop         | Any number of squares diagonally.                            |
| Gold General   | One step orthogonally or diagonally forward. Six directions. |
| Silver General | One step diagonally, or one step forward. Five directions.   |
| Pawn           | One step directly forward.                                   |

## PROMOTION

The promotion zone is the final rank only (rank 5 for Black, rank 1 for White). A piece may promote when it moves into or within the promotion zone. Promotion is mandatory when the Pawn reaches the final rank with no other legal move.

### Promoted pieces:

| BASE PIECE     | MOVEMENT WHEN PROMOTED                                  |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Rook           | Dragon King: Rook moves plus one square diagonally      |
| Bishop         | Dragon Horse: Bishop moves plus one square orthogonally |
| Silver General | Moves as Gold General                                   |
| Pawn           | Tokin: moves as Gold General                            |

Kings and Gold Generals do not promote.

## DROPS

The drop mechanic applies as in Standard Shogi. Captured pieces are held in hand and may be dropped onto any empty square on a later turn, unpromoted. Restrictions: no Pawn drop on a file already containing a friendly unpromoted Pawn; no Pawn drop for immediate checkmate; no drop where the piece would have no legal move.

## WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King. A player with no legal moves loses.

## DRAWS

**Sennichite:** The same position (including pieces in hand) occurs four times with the same player to move. Draw. If caused by perpetual check, the checking side loses.

**Impasse:** Both Kings enter the promotion zone and neither can be mated. Count material: Rooks and Bishops score 5 points each; all others score 1 point each. A player with fewer than 24 points loses. If both reach 24 or more, the game is a draw.

## ATTRIBUTION

Minishogi. Invented (or rediscovered) c. 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka. Rules freely published since then; game mechanics are not copyrightable. Sources: [pychess.org/variants/minishogi](https://pychess.org/variants/minishogi); Fairy-Stockfish variants.ini engine definition.